SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #91 · CHURCH & AUTHORITY

“Questioning my pastor is questioning God.”

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Where it often comes from

Teaching that the pastor speaks for God and must not be challenged. Leaders who used verses about authority to silence concerns. A church culture where questions were seen as rebellion or gossip. Respect for spiritual leaders learned in childhood. Experiences of being shamed for raising a concern.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture calls us to respect and support faithful leaders, who will give an account for how they care for the flock. But pastors are human and can be wrong. Paul opposed Peter to his face when Peter was in the wrong. The Bereans checked even Paul’s teaching against Scripture. Leaders are told not to lord it over the flock but to be examples. Raising an honest, respectful question is not rebellion against God; it can be faithfulness to Him.

> *“When Cephas came to Antioch, however, I opposed him to his face, because he stood to be condemned”* **(Galatians 2:11)**.

Also see

> “Now the Bereans were more noble-minded than the Thessalonians, for they received the message with great eagerness and examined the Scriptures every day to see if these teachings were true” **(Acts 17:11)**.

> “Be shepherds of God’s flock that is among you, watching over them not out of compulsion, but because it is God’s will; not out of greed, but out of eagerness; not lording it over those entrusted to you, but being examples to the flock” **(1 Peter 5:2–3)**.

> “Obey your leaders and submit to them, for they watch over your souls as those who must give an account. To this end, allow them to lead with joy and not with grief, for that would be of no advantage to you” **(Hebrews 13:17)**.

> “Not many of you should become teachers, my brothers, because you know that we who teach will be judged more strictly” **(James 3:1)**.

Common self-statements

- If I question my pastor, I’m rebelling against God.
- My pastor can’t be wrong.
- Raising concerns is gossip or division.
- God will punish me for disagreeing with a leader.
- I just need to submit and stay quiet.
- Good church members never ask questions.

Common logical errors

- **Appeal to authority:** Treating a leader’s words as if they were God’s words.
- **All-or-nothing thinking:** Believing you must either obey without question or be rebellious.
- **Fear-based thinking:** Staying silent out of fear rather than conviction.

- **Mental filter:** Remembering verses about submission while overlooking verses about testing teaching.

Challenging questions

- Did Paul ever disagree with another apostle?
- Did the Bereans check Paul's teaching against Scripture?
- What does 1 Peter 5:3 say leaders should not do?
- Can I respect a leader and still ask a question?
- Is my concern about Scripture, safety, or simply preference?
- How can I raise a question respectfully?
- Would a healthy leader welcome honest questions?

Truth summary

> Questioning my pastor is not the same as questioning God. Pastors are gifts to the church, and I can respect and support them. But they are human and can be wrong. I can test teaching by Scripture and raise honest concerns respectfully. Faithful leaders are examples, not lords over the flock.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Church
- Truth
- Communication
- Wisdom
- Humility

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Questioning my pastor is questioning God"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Questioning my pastor is questioning God." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Did Paul ever disagree with Peter?
- ☐ Did the Bereans check Paul's teaching?
- ☐ What should leaders not do?
- ☐ Can I respect a leader and ask questions?
- ☐ Is my concern about Scripture or preference?
- ☐ How can I ask respectfully?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Pastors are human and can be wrong.
- ☐ I can test teaching by Scripture.
- ☐ I can respect leaders and still ask questions.
- ☐ Faithful leaders do not lord it over the flock.
- ☐ Raising a concern can be faithfulness to God.
- ☐ God's Word is my final authority.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Galatians 2:11**
  "When Cephas came to Antioch, however, I opposed him to his face, because he stood to be condemned."
- [ ] **Acts 17:11**
  "Now the Bereans were more noble-minded than the Thessalonians, for they received the message with great eagerness and examined the Scriptures every day to see if these teachings were true."
- [ ] **1 Peter 5:2–3**
  "Be shepherds of God's flock that is among you, watching over them not out of compulsion, but because it is God's will; not out of greed, but out of eagerness; not lording it over those entrusted to you, but being examples to the flock."
- [ ] **Hebrews 13:17**
  "Obey your leaders and submit to them, for they watch over your souls as those who must give an account. To this end, allow them to lead with joy and not with grief, for that would be of no advantage to you."
- [ ] **James 3:1**
  "Not many of you should become teachers, my brothers, because you know that we who teach will be judged more strictly."

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Respectful question log:** When I have a concern, write the question, the Scripture involved, and a respectful way to ask it.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Acts 17:11 becomes: "Now **Sarah** is noble-minded, for **she** receives the message with great eagerness and examines the Scriptures every day to see if these teachings are true."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Church" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Write down one question you have about a teaching,** and look up what Scripture says.
- ☐ **Ask your pastor a question respectfully,** and notice how it is received.
- ☐ **Read Galatians 2:11–16,** and write why Paul spoke up.
- ☐ **If a leader responds with shame or threats,** talk with another trusted Christian or counselor.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Questioning my pastor is questioning God": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One question I tested by Scripture
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Questioning my pastor is questioning God.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, thank You for faithful leaders in my life. Help me reject the lie that questioning my pastor is questioning You. Give me a respectful heart, courage to ask honest questions, and wisdom to test everything by Your Word. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.